Siachen Glacier—the source of about a 100 million cubic meters of water—lay in ‘no man’s land’.



Image 9.2: Line of Control/Ceasefire Line
Source: Archives of AIM Television Pvt. Ltd.

But, India’s swift response of placing troops in the glaciated region stumped Zia’s adventure, and since 1984, Siachen has remained the world’s highest battlefield and an area of military dispute. Then, working to a plan, outlined in April 1988 by Gen. Zia-ul-Haq, Pakistan launched what is now their longest running quasi-military initiative against India—Operation Topac[5] (named so after a Latin American guerrilla movement).

Rajiv Gandhi, now India’s Prime Minister following the assassination of Indira Gandhi, took to Jagmohan’s advice to declare Governor’s rule and dismissed the G. M. Shah government for communal rioting. New Delhi’s biggest concern was that the communal tensions would end up posing as an additional security challenge, as Punjab was still unsettled. Kidnapping and grenade attacks on paramilitary posts became the norm in the valley, as the political leadership stood paralysed and confused. But the first to be at the